



circles

one tap to **hang out.**

THE VERIFIED SOCIAL GRAPH • COLUMBIA & BARNARD

Circles is a mobile-first social app that turns spontaneous intent —
"I'm grabbing coffee" or "studying at Butler" — into real-world
meetups among verified Columbia and Barnard students, in under
30 seconds.

WHY US

Four Columbia students building for our own campus.

Arjun Vaidya

MSCS @ Columbia

Dow Jones — consumer ML pipelines serving millions of readers

Product & ML lead — owns recommendation engine, matching algorithms, and product roadmap

Geonsik Moon

MSCS @ Columbia

ByteDance — recommendation systems ML engineer on TikTok-scale feeds

Feed & recommendations — built the real-time Pulse feed and activity ranking system

Inkeun Kim

MSCS @ Columbia

Full-stack engineer — shipped production real-time systems at scale

Shipping engineer — built the Supabase backend, .edu auth, and live presence layer

Alessandro Sayad

Columbia + École Polytechnique (dual degree)

CMA CGM — corporate strategy at a \$70B global logistics company

Growth & campus ops — runs ambassador program, merchant partnerships, and campus launch playbook

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Loneliest generation on record.

61%

of 18–25 yr olds report serious loneliness.

HARVARD • MCC 2021

71%

of Gen Z feels lonely. Boomers: 44%.

CIGNA • 2023

46%

of US teens online **almost constantly**.

PEW • 2024

Gen Z is the most connected generation in history — and the most isolated. The U.S. Surgeon General declared loneliness a public health epidemic, linking it to a **29% increase** in heart disease risk and **50% increase** in dementia risk. On college campuses, students are surrounded by thousands of peers yet struggle to convert proximity into real connection. The tools they use — Instagram, TikTok, group chats — were designed for broadcasting, not for inviting someone to grab coffee right now.

WHY COLUMBIA FIRST

Everyone wants to hang out.
No one wants to be **the one to ask.**

39K

verified students at Columbia +
Barnard.

ENROLLMENT • 2025

36

acres on Morningside.

DENSEST URBAN CAMPUS,
U.S.

1.1K

students per acre. [.edu](#) verified only.

TRUST GATE

Columbia is the ideal beachhead because it concentrates social friction in 36 walkable acres. Students live, study, eat, and socialize within minutes of each other — yet coordination costs remain high. There's no single app where a student can say "I'm at Butler, come study" and have verified peers show up. The density means any Circle posted is reachable in under five minutes on foot, collapsing the gap between intent and action.

Three things became true at the same time.

01

Gen Z left the curated feed.

Locket hit **#1 free app** by replacing the feed with live photos from real friends. Strava crossed **100M users** by sharing live activity, not highlight reels. The behavioral shift is clear: this generation wants presence over performance, authenticity over curation. Circles rides this wave — every post is real-time, ephemeral, and invitation-based.

02

Real-time is finally cheap.

Supabase Realtime + edge functions let two student engineers ship a production-grade presence layer in a weekend. Five years ago, this required a dedicated backend team and six-figure infrastructure spend. The cost curve has bent enough that a four-person team can build and scale a real-time social product without venture-scale capital upfront.

03

Loneliness data is undeniable.

61% of 18–25 yr olds report serious loneliness (Harvard, 2021). The U.S. Surgeon General's 2023 advisory links chronic loneliness to **+29%** heart disease risk and **+50%** dementia risk — on par with smoking 15 cigarettes per day. Universities and policymakers are actively seeking solutions, creating tailwinds for products that drive real-world connection.

CIRCLES, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

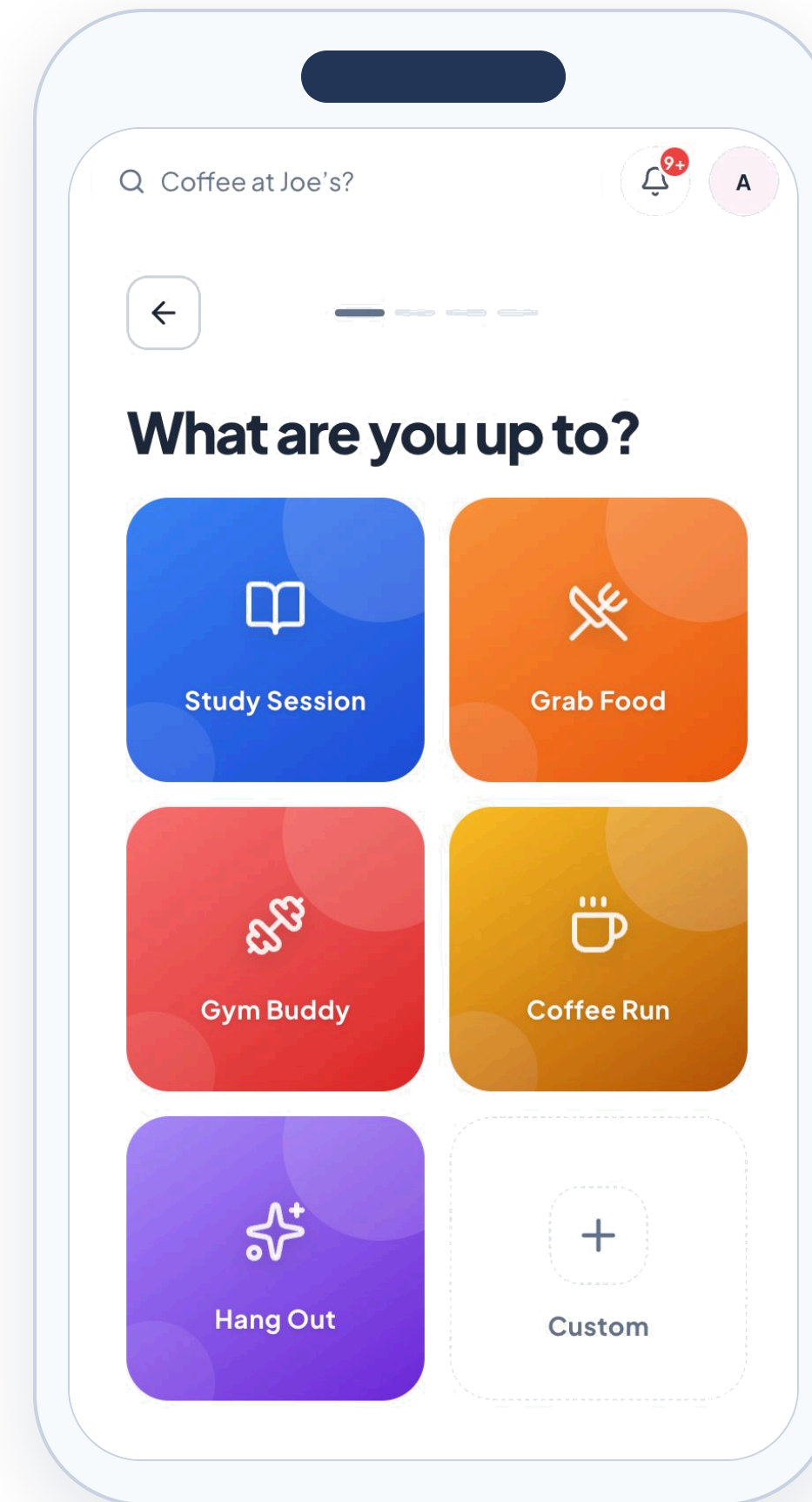
**You post what you're doing.
Right now. Others tap to join.**

That's it. No DMs. No coordinating across three group chats.

A Circle is a lightweight, ephemeral invitation: "Studying at Butler 3rd floor — join me." It lives in The Pulse, a real-time feed visible to all verified students. Anyone can tap to join; the host gets a notification; the joiner walks over — all in under 30 seconds.

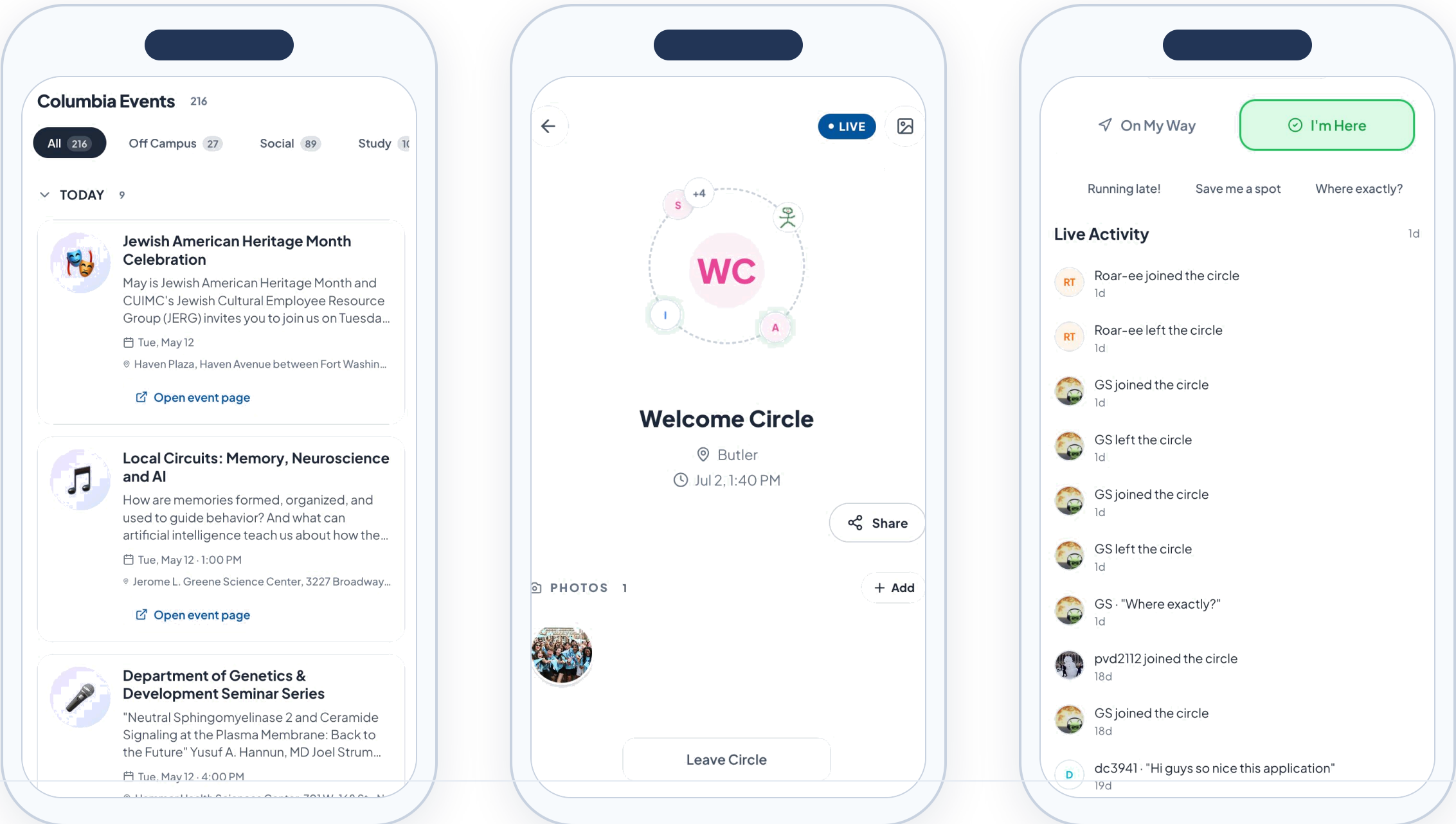
NETWORK

Verified Columbia and Barnard only. [.edu](#) email at signup; profile shows real name, year, and school.



HOW IT WORKS

Open the app. See campus, *alive*, in real time.



The Pulse is a live feed categorized by **Productivity**, **Social**, and **Off-Campus**. One tap and you're in — the host gets a ping, you walk over. That's the entire loop.

Join — host pinged.

Walk over — 30 sec.

WHAT STUDENTS DO TODAY

Every existing tool was built to broadcast — not invite.

GROUP CHATS

Decay by week 2.

Built for known cliques, not discovery. You can't join one you're not already in. New students are locked out of the social graph entirely.

SIDECCHAT · FIZZ

Anonymous venting.

Zero intent to meet. Anonymous apps trend toward negativity, making campus feel **worse**, not better. Circles is the opposite: real names, real invitations.

TIKTOK · INSTAGRAM

57% on TikTok daily.

Performance, not invitation. Posting a story isn't asking — it's broadcasting. Circles eliminates that friction: every post is an open invitation. (Pew, 2024)

THE DEFAULT

Doing **nothing**.

61% of 18–25 yr olds report serious loneliness. The real competitor is **inertia** — Circles reduces coordination energy to a single tap.

WHY CIRCLES WINS

Three compounding moats that get stronger with scale.

01**Verified trust layer.**

Every user is .edu-gated, creating a closed, high-trust network that anonymous apps cannot replicate. Trust is the prerequisite for sharing real-time location — and our primary moat.

02**Local network effects.**

Every new user makes the Pulse more valuable for everyone. More posts → more activities to join → more engagement → more users. A campus-level flywheel that's hard to displace at critical mass.

03**Behavioral habit formation.**

The core loop — open, browse, join — becomes a daily habit. When students check Circles before deciding what to do, we're the default coordination layer. This compounds each semester as new cohorts adopt during orientation.

THE SEED SIGNAL

Shipped. Instrumented. Validated on campus.

TODAY

LIVE IN PRODUCTION

circlesmain.vercel.app

Mobile-first single-page application built on Supabase with real-time subscriptions. Features include a live activity feed (The Pulse), .edu-gated authentication, a mutual friends graph, and automatic Columbia events import. Fully deployed and accessible to any student with a Columbia or Barnard email address.

VALIDATED ON R/COLUMBIA

"Great to see all campus events in a single place instead of sifting through emails or posters."

Unprompted top reply on our subreddit launch post. Students validated the core value proposition — a single, unified view of campus activity — without any prompting from the team.

INSTRUMENTED FROM DAY ONE

GA4 + Amplitude.

Full activation funnel measured from first visit. **14%** view-to-signup baseline conversion rate. Currently shipping iterative improvements — contextual prompts, social proof badges, and trust-building copy — to drive this toward 25%+ by Demo Day.

GROWTH TRAJECTORY

From Demo Day to campus dominance.

100+

verified students by Demo Day. Target 20% D7 retention — the benchmark for social product-market fit at early stage.

60%

Morningside penetration in 18 months. At 1,100 students per acre, 60% capture means the Pulse becomes the default way students coordinate spontaneous plans.

8

Tier 1 campuses online within 18 months. 24K verified students across NYU, Penn, Harvard, Yale, Stanford, USC, Georgetown, and Northwestern.

Our expansion playbook is campus-by-campus, ambassador-led. Each new campus launch follows a proven sequence: recruit 5 ambassadors → run a 2-week seeding sprint → hit 100 verified users → activate the local Pulse. Columbia is our proving ground; every campus after that benefits from the playbook, brand assets, and technical infrastructure we've already built.

HOW CIRCLES MAKES MONEY

Free for students. Always.

We monetize the network, not the user.

YEAR 1

Local merchants.

Hyperlocal sponsored Circles from Morningside operators — Hungarian Pastry, Joe Coffee, Mel's, Le Monde. Merchants pay to appear as suggested activities in The Pulse, reaching verified students within walking distance at the moment they're deciding what to do.

\$ 5 0 – \$ 2 0 0

per sponsored Circle. Capped per-feed ratio to preserve user trust and feed quality.

• CIRCLES

YEAR 2

Campus events & clubs.

Promoted Circles for Columbia's ~500 student organizations. Premium analytics showing reach, engagement, and attendance conversion. Event sponsorship slots that connect brands with highly-targeted campus audiences.

\$ 2 5 / M O

org subscriptions. ~5% pilot conversion target across 500 active student orgs.

YEAR 3 +

Verified network licensing.

License the verified-student-presence layer to peer universities and to brands paying a premium for real, opted-in college reach. Universities get a turnkey student engagement platform; brands get authenticated access to the most valuable consumer demographic.

\$ 3 0 / S T U D E N T / Y R

~\$1.8M ARR per 100K-student campus at 60% capture rate.

MARKET • BOTTOM-UP

One campus. Then eight. Then every campus.

01 Beachhead — Columbia + Barnard.

39,247 verified students. Densest urban campus in the U.S. Capture target: **60%+** in 18 months. ~\$700K ARR at full penetration.

02 Tier 1 — eight peer urban universities.

NYU, Penn, Harvard, Yale, Stanford, USC, Georgetown, Northwestern. **~240K** students. Same density, same playbook.

03 Tier 2 — every U.S. campus.

19.3M higher-ed students (NCES, 2024). SAM at \$30/student/yr = **\$579M**. At 10% penetration: \$58M ARR.

LONG TERM • GLOBAL

200

*million college students worldwide.
The platform becomes the verified
social graph this generation
actually uses — starting with
campuses, expanding to alumni
networks and young professional
communities.*

CAMPUS LAUNCH PLAYBOOK

Ambassador-led growth.

Zero paid acquisition.

01**Recruit 5 ambassadors.**

Target well-connected students across social clusters — athletes, club leaders, RAs. Each ambassador seeds 20 verified users in week one. Compensation: early access and merch, not cash.

02**Run a 2-week sprint.**

Ambassadors create 3–5 Circles daily during peak hours. This populates the Pulse so every new user sees a live, active feed — bridging the cold-start problem.

03**Hit critical mass.**

At ~100 verified users, the network sustains itself. Users create Circles unprompted, word-of-mouth drives signups, and the ambassador program scales down.

Why <\$5 CAC: The .edu gate is both constraint and channel. Verified students invite verified students — a trust-based loop requiring no paid ads.

TECHNICAL FOUNDATION

Built to scale from one campus to two hundred.

REAL-TIME INFRASTRUCTURE

Supabase Realtime + Edge Functions.

WebSocket presence layer delivers sub-second updates. Edge functions handle .edu verification, notifications, and Circle expiration. Scales to thousands of concurrent users per campus.

TRUST & SAFETY

.edu verification + real identity.

Every account requires a valid .edu email. Profiles display real name, year, and school — no pseudonyms. Accountability eliminates the toxicity plaguing anonymous apps.

ANALYTICS STACK

GA4 + Amplitude from day one.

Full-funnel instrumentation: visit → signup → first view → first join → first create → D7 return. Every product decision is data-informed with weekly cohort analysis.

HONEST ASSESSMENT

What could go wrong — and how we're mitigating it.

COLD START

Empty feed kills retention.

Mitigation: Ambassador-led seeding ensures the Pulse has real activity from day one. Columbia events are auto-imported so the feed is never empty. We launch in the densest part of campus (Morningside) to maximize the odds that any Circle is walkable within 5 minutes.

PLATFORM RISK

Big tech adds "hang out" features.

Mitigation: Instagram, Snapchat, and BeReal have all experimented with location-based features — none have built a .edu-gated, campus-specific coordination layer. Our moat is the verified trust network, not any single feature. Big platforms optimize for global scale; we optimize for hyperlocal density.

RETENTION

Social apps are notoriously fickle.

Mitigation: Circles is utility-first, not entertainment-first. Students use it to coordinate real-world plans, not to scroll. This functional anchor — "what's happening near me right now?" — creates a daily-use habit tied to real needs rather than algorithmic engagement tricks.

RAISING \$100K · 24 MO RUNWAY

Help us own Morningside.

USE OF FUNDS

Campus growth ops	\$40K
Product & infra	\$35K
Brand & design	\$25K

Four founders, no salaries through Demo Day. Capital deploys against ambassadors, on-campus seeding, analytics infrastructure, and the design cycle needed to ship a polished native app experience.

MILESTONES THIS BUYS

06	100+ verified students. 20% D7 retention. Product-market fit signal confirmed.
12	5K Morningside users. First merchant pilots generating revenue. Campus playbook documented.
18	60% Morningside penetration. NYU pilot launched. Metrics package ready for seed round.

CIRCLES · SPRING 2026

One tap to hang out.

Circles is the verified social coordination layer for college campuses. We turn spontaneous intent into real-world connection — starting at Columbia and Barnard, then scaling to every campus in the country.

Live at circlesmain.vercel.app

● **circles**

VAIDYA · MOON · KIM · SAYAD